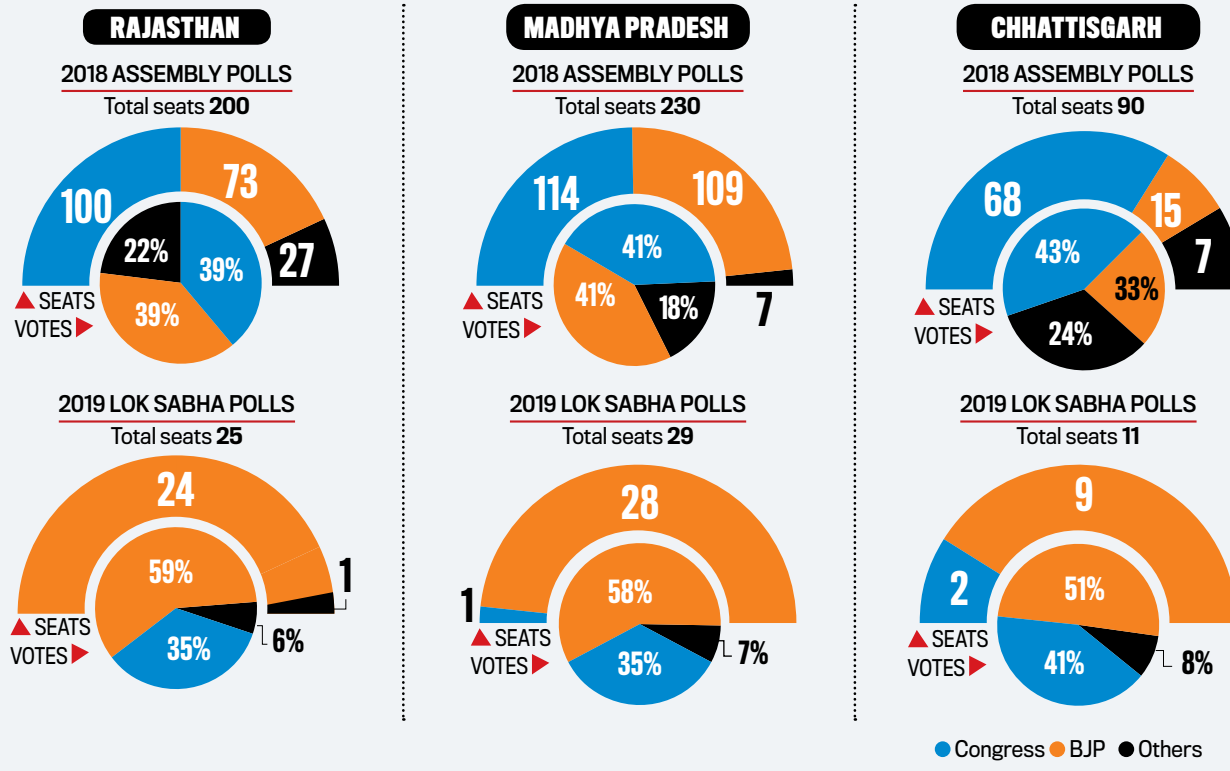
THE THREE BIG FIGHTS

Though the Congress won Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh in the **2018 assembly elections**, the party's fortunes saw a reversal in the **2019 Lok Sabha polls,** with the BJP almost making a clean sweep in all three states. The challenge for the Congress is to arrest the BJP's superlative performance in the Lok Sabha polls where votes are sought in the name of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. For the BJP, the key questions is: Will the Modi magic work again?



Graphic by **ASIT ROY**

their implementation—and his acceptability across all caste groups to help him return to power and change the course of history. Since 1998, the Congress and the BJP have been swapping power every five years—it was the Congress that won 100 seats against the BJP's 73 in the 200-member House the last time. If Gehlot wants to buck this trend, he must have an answer to counter the Gujjars rallying for Pilot, who is from this community. The state's eight Gujjar MLAs—all in the Congress—are split equally between Gehlot and Pilot. Gehlot is now trying to bring to his fold anti-Gujjar castes, including Mali, which he belongs to, and Meena, a Scheduled Tribe in eastern Rajasthan.

Pilot's campaign has embarrassed Gehlot as the BJP tried to make corruption in his government a big issue. Pilot accuses Gehlot of ignoring the corruption charges against his predecessor Vasundhara Raje of the BJP. Some in the BJP are secretly expressing happiness over Pilot's move as they don't want Raje to lead the BJP in the state again. She is also said to be out of favour with the RSS. In fact, there are half a dozen CM aspirants in the BJP. But the central leadership is gradually inclining towards Raje for a comfortable win. The party replaced hardcore anti-Raje RSS man Satish Poonia as state president with milder C.P. Joshi—who is not from an RSS background. But the challenge now for the central leadership is to make peace between second-rung leaders and Raje by suggesting that she will be removed in the fourth year if she does not perform. As the Congress did in Karnataka, the BJP also needs to keep its house united and combat the Gehlot government on local issues, instead of depending on the Modi magic to see them through.

THE CONGRESS'S LEADERSHIP ISSUE IS SETTLED IN MADHYA PRADESH. KAMAL NATH IS THE CM FACE AND HE SHARES A GREAT RAPPORT WITH EX-CM DIGVIJAYA SINGH